

Artists object to copy-protected CDs

Record labels are catering to digital music junkies more than ever before. And so, to prevent users from copying tracks to hard drives, they released copy-protected CDs, and instead supplied a copy of all the songs on secure digital formats such as Windows Media, which can then be transferred to hard drives and portable music players. While the record labels are satisfied with this approach, there's a slight problem of royalties. Song writers and music publishers, who get paid for every copy of the song sold, contend that since these unique double-format discs hold two copies of the song, they should be paid for both. While this is an issue that has been argued over for months, the problem has become rather acute as hundreds of millions of such copy-protected CDs have been sold. This raises the spectre of huge back payments. With music publishers and artistes getting as little as 7 to 8 cents (US) for every copy of the song sold, and record labels trying to push for greater profits—in a market that they claim is depressed because of file swapping—here's yet another stumbling block to copy-protected CDs.

snapshot

NASA's Mars Rover sites witnessed data transfers of 34.6 TB, and had over 260 million hits per day

Source: NASA/eTouch

British song-swappers may now be sued

The British Phonographic Industry (BPI) may now begin doing in Britain what the RIAA and similar groups have been doing in America. In a recent announcement, the BPI said that it 'may' sue people who swap songs over the Internet. Andrew Yeates, director-general, BPI, said that the organization was hoping to encourage new, legitimate services such as iTunes. Such services are expected to be launched in Europe later this year.

In the US, the cases that the RIAA had initiated against song-swappers gener-

ated bad publicity, after it turned out that amongst those targeted, were a 12-year-old girl and a 66-year-old grandmother. Surprisingly, the decision to sue

song-swappers in the UK came just after CD sales in the UK hit a record high of 121 million units in 2003.

Regarding the steps the BPI was taking, a spokesman said that they were holding talks with ISPs across Europe, with the intention of streamlining a process that would identify Netizens distributing the most songs.



tomorrow's technology

Ultrasonic at heart

Current medical ultrasonic equipment is bulky, but this could change if crucial parts of the machine were placed inside the human body. Butrus T Khuri-Yakub, a scientist at Stanford University, has developed a prototype of a miniature ultrasonic device. He is working on developing a 3D medical imaging system that will fit on a catheter, which can be fitted inside arteries. The technology is called capacitive micro-machined ultrasonic transducer. Currently, piezoelectrics are used in ultrasonic equipment, but new transducers utilise silicon manu-

facturing techniques, and can be shaped and integrated with electronics.

Tiny drum-like transducers made from silicon, and a membrane of Silicon nitride is put on the drumheads. An electrical signal, applied between the membrane and the silicon substrate, generates an electric field, causing the drumheads to vibrate and emit ultrasonic waves. The waves are converted into acoustic beams that hit tumours and artery walls. The drumheads pick up the reflected beams, and produce electrical signals, which are used to construct images.

quoteworthy

"Software is not becoming free, but it is becoming a commodity.... Open source is good for general software such as the kernel and development tools, and commercial software is good for specialist software."

Linux pioneer, Linus Torvalds in an interview with *Computerworld*. Torvalds works full time on Linux kernel development with the Open Source Development Lab, a consortium supported by corporates to further developments in Linux.

"For me, I'm looking for a situation where I have a lot of freedom around the development of our products, and the way those products come to market."

Ed Fries, formerly head of Microsoft Games. He leaves Microsoft after having worked with them for 18 years.

"There are acupuncture points in integrated systems like power supply systems, railway signalling systems... any attack on these points would disable many services."

Arun Shourie, Minister for IT and Communications, announcing the setting up of the Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-IN) to tackle hacking and virus attack. (<http://www.cert-in.org.in/>)